



UCT CLASSIC THESIS TEMPLATE

CANDIDATE NAME

Doctor of Philosophy
Department or Research Unit
Faculty or School
University Name

19 April, 2026

Supervised by: Primary Supervisor & Co-supervisor or Second Supervisor

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INSTITUTION

Department or Research Unit

Faculty or School

University Name

ABSTRACT

Replace this abstract with a concise overview of the proposal. A useful structure is:

- the research problem and why it matters;
- the gap in the current literature or practice;
- the proposed approach;
- the expected contribution and impact.

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ACRONYMS

AI	Artificial Intelligence
HCI	Human-Computer Interaction
ML	Machine Learning
NLP	Natural Language Processing
PhD	Doctor of Philosophy

INTRODUCTION

This document is a reusable proposal template built from a complete thesis-style Typst project. It preserves examples of common proposal elements so that the file remains useful when drafting a new submission. Replace the prose, figures, tables, and references with project-specific material as needed.¹

1.1 CONTEXT

Introduce the broad research area, the practical or scientific context, and the reason this topic deserves investigation. In a proposal, the introduction normally establishes the domain, motivates the topic, and narrows toward the specific gap addressed later in the document.

¹This is an example footnote. Use footnotes sparingly for clarifications that would otherwise interrupt the main argument.



Figure 1.1
Example full-width figure. Replace this file and caption with a conceptual overview, system diagram, study area map, or workflow figure relevant to the proposed research.

1.2 PROBLEM OVERVIEW

State the problem clearly. Focus on what is missing, broken, unknown, or inefficient in the current state of the field. The discussion should move from broad context to a precise statement of the unresolved issue. If the proposal includes a system, platform, or framework, this section is also a good place to introduce it at a high level before the technical details appear later.

1.2.1 ILLUSTRATIVE SUBPROBLEM

This paragraph is the first one after the heading, so it starts flush left. It demonstrates the opening paragraph style used in the template when a new section or subsection begins.

This second paragraph demonstrates the indented continuation style. Use this pattern when you want separation between paragraphs to come from the first-line indent rather than from extra vertical space.

1.2.1.1 SCOPE NOTE

Use a fourth-level heading sparingly. In a thesis or proposal, it is most useful when a short, tightly bounded clarification needs its own label without becoming a full new section.

1.3 DOCUMENT STRUCTURE

Briefly orient the reader to the remaining chapters. For example, explain where the literature review, research questions, methodology, and timeline are described. The template includes cross-references so that you can see how a longer academic document hangs together; for instance, the methodology chapter later demonstrates a numbered equation and a summary table.

BACKGROUND AND LITERATURE REVIEW

Use this chapter to position the proposal within the existing body of knowledge. The aim is not to summarise everything, but to show command of the area and isolate the specific opening for the proposed contribution.

2.1 FOUNDATIONAL CONCEPTS

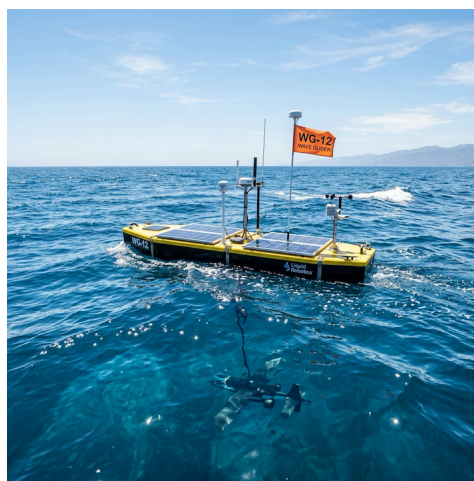
Define the core ideas, terminology, and frameworks needed to understand the project. Keep definitions concise and introduce only the concepts required to make the later research design legible.

2.2 PRIOR WORK

Summarise the most relevant literature thematically rather than paper-by-paper. A short proposal usually benefits from grouping sources by method, theory, dataset, or application area. For example, an overview source can be cited directly [[1]], while supporting claims can be cited parenthetically elsewhere.



(a) Example image panel A



(b) Example image panel B

Figure 2.1
Example subfigure layout. Use this pattern when comparing prior systems, datasets, instruments, study sites, or design alternatives.

2.3 GAP ANALYSIS

Conclude with the specific gap your research will address. This should connect directly to the research questions in the next chapter. A strong gap statement is specific, bounded, and matched to a feasible method rather than framed as an open-ended ambition.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS AND OBJECTIVES

3.1 RESEARCH AIM

State the overall aim of the project in one paragraph.

3.2 RESEARCH QUESTIONS

1. Replace this item with your primary research question.
2. Add secondary questions if the project requires them.
3. Keep the list tightly aligned with the proposed methods.

3.3 OBJECTIVES

- Define the concrete objective(s) required to answer the research questions.
- Ensure each objective can be traced to a method, dataset, or analysis step.

METHODOLOGY

This chapter should explain how the research questions will be answered and why the chosen approach is appropriate. The examples below demonstrate common proposal elements that are often expected in reviewable academic documents.

4.1 RESEARCH DESIGN

Describe whether the project is theoretical, experimental, qualitative, quantitative, computational, mixed-methods, or another design. State why the design matches the research questions and what evidence it will produce.

4.2 DATA OR MATERIALS

Explain what data, participants, case studies, instruments, simulations, or source materials will be used. If the project includes a hardware, software, or systems component, an architecture figure is often useful.

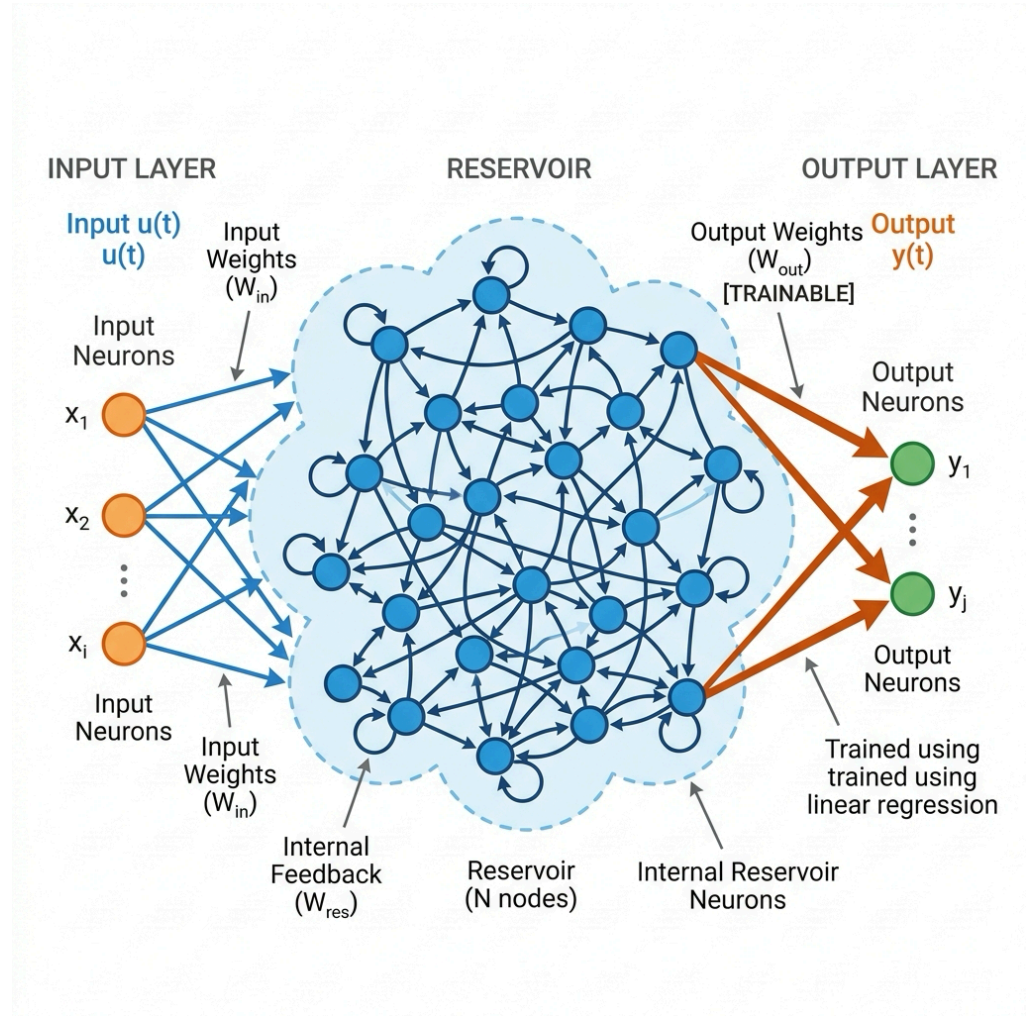


Figure 4.1
Example methodology figure. Replace this with a workflow, architecture, pipeline, sampling design, or study process diagram.

4.3 METHODS OF ANALYSIS

Outline the analytical methods, modelling techniques, experiments, or evaluation procedures that will be applied. If your work uses mathematical modelling, this chapter is a natural place for equations such as:

$$(4.1) \quad J(\theta) = \sum_{i=1}^n w_i (y_i - \hat{y}_{i(\theta)})^2$$

Here, $J(\theta)$ is a generic objective function, w_i are optional weights, y_i are observed values, and $\hat{y}_{i(\theta)}$ are model predictions. Replace this example with the notation appropriate to the project.

WORK PACKAGE	PURPOSE	EVIDENCE OUTPUT
Literature synthesis	Establishes the current state of knowledge and identifies the gap	Review chapter or annotated matrix
Pilot or feasibility work	Tests assumptions, access, instrumentation, or analytic workflow	Pilot report or revised protocol
Main analysis	Produces the primary evidence needed to answer the research questions	Results, models, or thematic findings
Validation or evaluation	Assesses robustness, generalisability, or practical performance	Comparative metrics or triangulated findings

Table 4.1
Example summary
table for a
methodology chapter.

4.4 ETHICS AND RISK

Document any ethical approval requirements, operational risks, data governance constraints, or feasibility concerns. If the proposal involves human participants, sensitive data, fieldwork, or hazardous environments, reviewers will usually expect this material to be explicit.

4.5 EXPECTED CONTRIBUTION

State what the project is expected to contribute to knowledge, practice, or policy. Make the contribution proportionate to the scope of a PhD proposal and tightly coupled to the methods already described.

RESOURCES AND FEASIBILITY

5.1 REQUIRED RESOURCES

List the major resources needed to complete the project, such as equipment, software, datasets, travel, lab access, or participant recruitment.

5.2 BUDGET NOTES

If your department requires a costing section, replace this text with a concise table of expected expenses and funding assumptions.

ITEM	BASIS	ESTIMATED COST
Software or compute access	Annual license, compute credits, or lab platform access	\$0.00
Fieldwork or travel	Replace with trip assumptions, accommodation, and transport	\$0.00
Data collection materials	Replace with equipment, participant costs, or consumables	\$0.00
Conference dissemination	Registration, travel, and poster or printing costs	\$0.00
Total		\$0.00

Table 5.1
Example budget table
for proposal planning.

5.3 FEASIBILITY

Explain why the scope is realistic for the available time, supervision, infrastructure, and budget. It is useful to connect the feasibility argument to the staged plan shown in the Project Timeline chapter.

PROJECT TIMELINE

6.1 MILESTONES

Replace this chapter with a Gantt chart, milestone table, or phase-based timeline. Typical milestones include literature review, pilot work, data collection, analysis, writing, and submission.

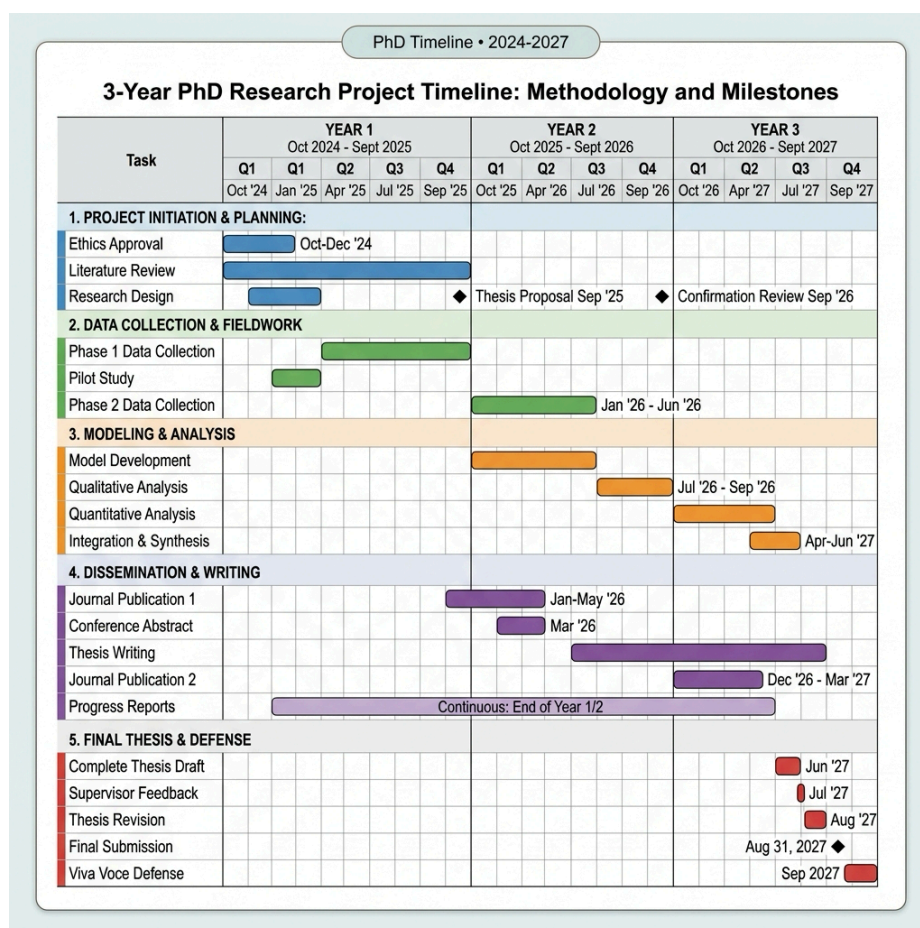


Figure 6.1
Example timeline graphic. Replace this with your own Gantt chart, milestone diagram, or phased project plan.

6.2 CONTINGENCIES

Note the main schedule risks and the fallback plan if access to data, equipment, field sites, or participants is delayed.

CONCLUSION

Close the proposal by restating the problem, the planned approach, and the expected contribution. This chapter should be short and should reinforce why the project is worthwhile and feasible. The template now includes examples of figures, a numbered equation, and tables so the document remains a practical starting point rather than an empty shell.

REFERENCES

- [1] E. Author, "Placeholder Reference for Template Validation." 2026.